AUTHORITY, AI SEARCH & STRATEGY - SECTION 42

Tool Stack, Selling SEO, Your Roadmap

One platform, one crawler, and Search Console covers almost everything. Then: what to charge, and what to do on Monday.

Bottom line

The 2026 stack is one all-in-one platform plus Screaming Frog plus Search Console. Retainers dominate at **78.2%** of engagements, standard SMB work runs **$1,500 to $5,000/month**, and results take **6 to 12 months**. The last section of this course is the 90-day plan that turns everything above into sequenced work.

The tool stack

Tool	Best at	2026 cost	Free option
Semrush	Multi-channel (SEO + PPC + social), 140+ technical checks, white-label reporting	**$129.95 to $139.95+**/mo Pro	10 searches/day
Ahrefs	Backlinks and competitive research, 36-trillion link index refreshed every 15 to 30 min	**$108 to $129+**/mo Lite	Webmaster Tools, owned domains only
Moz Pro	Domain Authority, beginner-friendly	**$31 to $99+**/mo	MozBar extension
Screaming Frog	Deep technical crawling, JS rendering, redirect chains	**Free to 500 URLs**, then **$259/yr**	Yes, genuinely usable
Peec AI	Multi-LLM citation tracking, 7+ platforms	**$95/mo**	No
Dageno AI	AI share of voice and sentiment, 10+ platforms	Free plan	Yes

`[practitioner]`

Is free enough? For a site under 500 URLs, **Search Console plus free Screaming Frog genuinely covers technical and performance work.** That is most of Tier 3 with no budget at all.

What free does **not** cover: competitor intelligence, backlink discovery, and scaled rank tracking. Those are the reasons to pay.

Which paid platform: Ahrefs for link work, and its Traffic Potential metric is genuinely better than keyword volume because it estimates whole-SERP traffic. Semrush for agencies needing PPC data and white-label reports. You need one, not both, and most people who own both use one.

> **A vendor claim, flagged**
> Ahrefs' internal data claims its crawler finds **35% more referring domains than Semrush and 68% more than Moz**. That is a vendor measuring itself against its competitors. Directional at best.

AI visibility tracking is a new, separate line item. It is not bundled into the traditional platforms yet. Start with a manual monthly spreadsheet per Section 39, and pay for a tool only once the manual version is a real burden.

Pricing SEO

Retainers dominate at 78.2% of engagements. `[practitioner]` SEO compounds, so the commercial model that matches the work is ongoing.

Segment	Monthly	What it buys
Local entry	**$500 to $1,500**	GBP management, local citations, 1-2 content pieces
Standard SMB	**$1,500 to $5,000**	Technical health, 3-5 content pieces, semantic SEO, basic outreach
Growth / mid-market	**$5,000 to $15,000**	8-15+ content pieces, advanced link building, dedicated strategist
Enterprise	**$15,000 to $75,000+**	Account team, complex architecture, AI visibility infrastructure

B2B tech runs higher: Series A budgets **$15k to $30k/mo**, pre-IPO **$60k to $150k+/mo**. `[practitioner]`

Project pricing:

- Technical SEO audit: **$2,000 to $15,000**, median **$7,500** for 50 to 500 page sites
- Site migration support: **$5,000 to $30,000+**
- Content strategy and cluster map: **$4,000 to $12,000**

The five models:

1. **Retainer**, 78.2% of professionals, for compounding growth
2. **Hourly, $75 to $300/hr**, for consulting and training only. **Hourly for ongoing execution is a red flag**, because it penalizes your own efficiency and makes cost unpredictable for the client
3. **Project**, for launches and migrations with a defined end
4. **Performance-based**, rare, and most agencies avoid 100% performance as unsustainable
5. **Hybrid retainer plus milestone**, the 2026 trend for incentive alignment

Scoping honestly

Price against competitive difficulty, not against effort. `[practitioner]`

- **KD 0-15** supports **$500 to $1,000/mo**
- **KD 30-45** needs a **$2,000 to $3,500/mo minimum**

Quoting below the competitive floor guarantees failure, and it is the most common way an SEO engagement dies. The client is not underpaying for your time, they are underpaying for the outcome they were promised, and no amount of effort closes that gap. Walking away from an underpriced engagement is better for both parties than taking it and failing.

The timeline, stated upfront every time:

Phase	Months	What actually happens
Foundation	1-3	Technical fixes, schema, strategy. **Minimal traffic movement**
Early traction	4-6	Long-tail rankings, indexing gains
Measurable impact	6-12	Meaningful traffic and lead growth
Competitive markets	12-18+	Full ROI

Say this before signing, not in month four when the client asks why nothing has happened. The months 1-3 row is the one that ends engagements, and pre-framing it is the single highest-value sentence in an SEO sales conversation.

Never guarantee rankings. Nobody controls Google. An agency guaranteeing a position is either misunderstanding the system or misrepresenting it.

> **An honest gap in the research**
> despite a pass aimed directly at it, the corpus produced no solid evidence on **client churn rates, standard contract lengths, or a documented rationale for why ranking guarantees are a red flag** beyond the self-evident point above. Treat those as unresearched rather than settled. Saying "I don't have data on that" is the habit this whole course has been arguing for.

Positioning SEO in 2026

Three shifts worth building an offer around:

1. AI visibility is a distinct, sellable service. Most providers are still selling 2023 SEO. Sections 36 through 40 are a differentiated offer, and almost nobody is delivering them.

2. The reporting has to change. Per Section 34, an unlinked mention now has independent value. Per Section 41, citation share is a metric. Reporting only rankings and links is reporting the wrong things.

3. Honesty about evidence is a positioning asset. This entire course has separated `[confirmed]` from `[practitioner]`. Doing that in a sales conversation, saying "this number is vendor-sourced and correlational, here is what I'd act on and why", is unusual enough to be a differentiator on its own.

Your 90-day roadmap

Days 1-30: foundation and truth.

- Full technical audit: crawl, index, canonicals, redirects (Sections 21-25)
- Search Console and GA4 configured properly (Sections 10 and 41)
- Keyword research and cluster map (Sections 6-8)
- Baselines recorded: rankings, links, brand mentions, AI citation share
- Fix anything blocking indexation. Nothing else matters until this is clean

Days 31-60: content and on-page.

- Rewrite titles and metas on the top 20 pages (Section 11)
- Restructure the top 5 pages for extraction (Section 37)
- Publish the first cluster (Section 15)
- Internal linking pass (Section 16)
- Core Web Vitals on the worst template (Sections 27-28)
- Entity work started: Entity Home, `sameAs`, Wikidata (Section 40)

Days 61-90: authority and AI.

- Unlinked mention reclamation (Section 33)
- One original research asset drafted (Section 33)
- Third-party platform presence to four or more (Section 34)
- AI crawler policy set (Section 40)
- Citation tracking running monthly (Sections 39 and 41)
- Local work if applicable (Section 35)
- First 90-day report with an action log (Section 41)

Then repeat the cycle. SEO does not have a finish line, it has a cadence: audit, fix, publish, measure, adjust.

Where you are now

You have worked through 42 sections across four tiers. The capstone site is audited, measured, optimized, technically sound, marked up, authority-baselined and AI-visible.

The three things worth carrying out of this course:

Evidence tiers. You now separate what Google confirmed from what a vendor asserted. That habit is worth more than any individual tactic here, because the tactics change and the habit does not.

Floors versus levers. Core Web Vitals, mobile, HTTPS are floors. Pass and stop. Content, authority and topical coverage are levers. Knowing which is which is where most SEO budgets are wasted.

Comprehensive coverage beats optimized pages. It was true for topical authority before AI search existed, and query fan-out made it more true. **80%+ topical coverage retains 85.4% of AI visibility.**

Do this now

1. **Pick your one paid tool**, or confirm free is genuinely enough for your site size.
2. **Install Screaming Frog** if you have not. Free to 500 URLs.
3. **Write your scoped SEO offer:** which segment, what deliverables, what monthly price, based on the tables above.
4. **Write your timeline paragraph** and commit to saying it before every engagement.
5. **Set your competitive floor.** What KD are you targeting, and what minimum does that require?
6. **Build the 90-day plan for your own site**, dated, with the sections listed above.
7. **Diarize the monthly cadence**: report, citation check, refresh pass, action log.
8. **Re-read the sections you skimmed.** You will have skimmed some.

Capstone step

Your capstone is complete. You have a live, audited, measured, optimized site with an entity identity and AI visibility tracking, plus a written productized SEO offer with pricing and an honest timeline, and a dated 90-day plan for the next cycle.

Key takeaways

- One all-in-one platform plus Screaming Frog plus Search Console covers almost everything. Under 500 URLs, free genuinely works for technical and performance.
- Retainers are **78.2%** of engagements. Standard SMB is **$1,500 to $5,000/mo**, and quoting below the competitive difficulty floor guarantees failure.
- Results take **6 to 12 months**, and months 1-3 show minimal movement. Say so before signing, and never guarantee rankings.
- Carry three things forward: evidence tiers, floors versus levers, and comprehensive coverage over optimized pages.